



READING RISK | FOR SWIMMERS

CHECK

READ THE CONDITIONS

CHECK FOR SWIMMERS

Read the water in front of you before you commit to the swim you had in mind.

CLARITY · HAZARDS · ENVIRONMENT · CHEMISTRY · KINETICS

WHO THIS IS FOR

For anyone standing at the edge of open water: a quick dip, a regular pod swim, a long training swim, or a first visit to a venue you do not know yet.

READ THIS GUIDE ONLINE

<https://www.openwaterswimming.com/learn/resources/check-framework-for-swimmers>

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INTRODUCTION

CHECK FOR SWIMMERS

CHECK is the pre-swim read. Five ways of looking at the same water, resolving into one honest answer: swim it as planned, change the swim, or leave it for another day.

None of the five is a pass or fail test. They are prompts that surface what you already half noticed, early enough to act on it while you are still dry.

THE COMPONENTS

CLARITY · HAZARDS · ENVIRONMENT · CHEMISTRY · KINETICS

C CLARITY

HOW WELL CAN YOU SEE, AND BE SEEN, IN THIS WATER TODAY?

Clarity is visibility and findability. It covers how far you can see under the surface, how far you can see across it, and how easily someone on shore or in a craft could pick you out if they needed to.

Light, glare, surface chop, sediment, algae and weather all change it, and it can change within one swim as the sun drops or the wind gets up.

ASK

If I needed to be found right now, how easily could someone see me?

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- Underwater visibility: whether you can see your own hand, the bottom, or nothing at all.
- Surface visibility across the swim: haze, glare, low sun, rain or mist.
- Whether anyone on shore can actually see the part of the water you are heading for.
- How visible you will be: cap color, tow float where appropriate, and the light you will finish in.

IF SOMETHING CHANGES

- Add visibility before you add distance: a bright cap, a tow float where it suits the swim, or a swim closer to shore.
- Tell someone your route and your expected finish time, and tell them when you are out.
- If you cannot be seen from where you will be swimming, change the route rather than the plan for being rescued.
- Bring the swim forward or shorten it if the light is going.

A swim that felt fine at four o'clock can be a different swim at six, in the same water, with the same swimmer.

H HAZARDS

WHAT HERE COULD HURT YOU OR MAKE THIS SWIM HARDER THAN YOU EXPECT?

Hazards are the specific things in and around this water that could cause harm: boat traffic, weed, submerged structures, rocks, sudden depth changes, jellyfish, difficult entries and exits, or a shoreline you cannot climb out of once you are past it.

ASK

What is in this water, and what would I do if I met it?

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- Boat, jet ski and paddle traffic, and whether swimmers are expected here at all.
- Entry and exit points, and whether the ones you plan to use are actually usable today.
- Weed beds, rocks, drop-offs, submerged debris and slipways.
- Local warnings, signage or advice from people who swim here regularly.

IF SOMETHING CHANGES

- Route around the hazard rather than through it, even if it makes the swim longer.
- Walk the exit you intend to use before you rely on it.
- Stay inside a line where a boat operator can reasonably expect a swimmer to be.
- If you do not know the venue, ask someone who does before you go far from shore.

E ENVIRONMENT

READ THE VENUE AND THE DAY, NOT THE MEMORY OF LAST TIME.

Environment is temperature, weather, wind, light and the venue itself. Air temperature, wind and shelter at the exit matter too, because cooling can continue after you leave the water.

ASK

Is this the same venue I remember, in the conditions that exist right now?

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- Water temperature, and how it compares to what you are used to swimming in.
- Air temperature, wind chill and shelter at the exit point.
- Weather that is due to change during the swim window.
- Whether the venue has changed since last time: new debris, altered banks, higher or lower water.

IF SOMETHING CHANGES

- Adjust the length of the swim to the water temperature, conditions, exposure and what you are used to.
- Set out warm clothing and a hot drink before you get in, not after.
- Swim into the wind first where you can, so the harder half is the early half.
- If the venue has changed, treat it as a new venue.

C CHEMISTRY

CONSIDER WHAT YOU ARE SWIMMING IN, NOT JUST HOW IT LOOKS.

Chemistry is water quality and exposure. Recent heavy rain, storm overflows, agricultural runoff, algal blooms and stagnant warm water can all change the health risk of the same familiar spot.

Clear water is not proof of clean water, and murky water is not always contaminated. Look for information about the venue rather than judging by appearance alone.

ASK

Has anything happened recently that would change what is in this water?

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- Recent heavy rainfall, known discharge, runoff, or local guidance that identifies a current concern.
- Visible algal bloom, discoloration, foam, scum or an unusual smell.
- Published bathing water quality information or local advisories for this venue.
- Whether you have any open wound, recent illness or reason to be more cautious than usual.

IF SOMETHING CHANGES

- Postpone rather than accept an active advisory or a visible bloom.
- Avoid swallowing water, and rinse and wash after the swim.
- If you have an open cut or wound, check current health guidance for the water. Stay out where advised, or completely cover the wound with a waterproof bandage where that is appropriate.
- If you feel unwell in the days after a swim, mention the swim to a clinician.



KINETICS

READ HOW THE WATER IS MOVING, AND WHERE IT WILL TAKE YOU.

Kinetics is movement: tide, current, swell, chop, river flow and wind against water. Moving water decides how much of your swim is optional. A swim that goes out easily can be a swim you cannot come back from.

ASK

If I stopped swimming here, where would the water take me?

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- Tide state and turn times, and how they change during the swim window.
- Current direction and strength, including river flow after rain.
- Wind against tide or current, which builds steep, short chop.
- Whether the return leg is the harder leg.

IF SOMETHING CHANGES

- Swim the harder direction first, while you are freshest.
- Pick a route where the water moves you toward an exit, not away from one.
- Set a turnaround point and a turnaround time before you get in.
- If you cannot describe where the water would carry you, that is the reason to stay closer to shore.

PUTTING IT TOGETHER

YOU READ FIVE THINGS. NOW MAKE ONE DECISION.

Do not average the five. Read them together and decide what swim actually fits the water in front of you today.

GO / SWIM IT AS PLANNED

Nothing in the five stands out, the conditions match what you prepared for, and someone knows where you are and when you will be out.

MODIFY / CHANGE THE SWIM, NOT THE DECISION TO SWIM

One or more inputs suggest a shorter, closer, brighter or better supported version of the same swim. Change the swim before you get in, not halfway through it.

NO SWIM TODAY / LEAVE IT FOR ANOTHER DAY

An active water quality advisory, conditions well beyond your experience, no usable exit, or a movement of water you cannot account for. The water will be there next week.

OVERRIDE

One serious concern is enough on its own. It does not need to be outvoted by four things that looked fine.

QUICK CHECK

Think about your last swim here. Which of the five did you assume rather than actually look at?

COMPOUND RISK

THE INPUTS INTERACT

The five inputs interact. Each one can look acceptable while the combination changes the swim.

- Visibility is a little lower than usual.
- The wind has picked up slightly.
- The water is a couple of degrees colder than last week.

Together they describe a swim where you are harder to see, working harder, and cooling faster than planned. Read the combination, not the list.

WHERE THIS LEADS NEXT

KEEP GOING

PRIMARY

CONTINUE WITH ABLE

You read the water. Now read yourself, at the water's edge.

<https://www.openwaterswimming.com/learn/resources/able-for-swimmers>

RELATED

COMPOUND RISK FOR SWIMMERS

How several acceptable factors combine into one that is not.

<https://www.openwaterswimming.com/learn/resources/compound-risk-for-swimmers>

EXPLORE

EXPLORE ALL READING RISK GUIDES

Fifteen guides for swimmers, coaches and organizers.

<https://www.openwaterswimming.com/learn/resources>

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

REFERENCES

CDC, how to safely visit oceans, lakes and rivers

<https://www.cdc.gov/healthy-swimming/safety/how-to-safely-visit-oceans-lakes-and-rivers.html>

Tipton and Bradford, cold and warm water immersion: a review of the physiological responses relevant to open water swimming

<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC4052348/>

Canonical guide: <https://www.openwaterswimming.com/learn/resources/check-framework-for-swimmers>

World Open Water Swimming Association, WOWSA Learn.